

AFTER THE UNTHINKABLE

A Grief Journal for
Suicide Loss Survivors

You did not cause this.
You could not have prevented this.
You are not alone.

Daniel Tesfamariam

AFTER THE UNTHINKABLE

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This journal is not a substitute for grief counseling.

If you are in crisis: Call 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline)

AFSP: afsp.org | Alliance of Hope: allianceofhope.org

YOU ARE NOT ALONE

If you are holding this journal, you have experienced one of the most devastating losses a human can face. The death of someone you love by suicide.

This grief is different. It comes with:

- Questions that may never be answered
- Guilt that does not belong to you
- Anger at the person you love and miss
- Stigma that silences your pain
- A loneliness that feels impossible to explain

This journal is a safe space. There are no wrong feelings here.

Write as much or as little as you need. Skip pages. Come back.

Your grief is valid. Your love is real. You will survive this.

THE UNIQUE GRIEF OF SUICIDE LOSS

Suicide grief is complicated by factors other losses don't carry:

The 'Why':

The endless search for reasons that may never fully satisfy.

The 'If Only':

Replaying moments, wondering if you missed signs.

The Stigma:

Others may not know what to say, or say hurtful things.

The Anger:

It's okay to be angry at someone you love and mourn.

The Guilt:

Survivor's guilt is universal in suicide loss - and undeserved.

The Trauma:

You may have found them. You may replay the notification.

DAY 1

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 2

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 3

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 4

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 5

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 6

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 7

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 8

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 9

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 10

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 11

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 12

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 13

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 14

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 15

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 16

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 17

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 18

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 19

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 20

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 21

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 22

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 23

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 24

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 25

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 26

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 27

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 28

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I'm carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 29

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

DAY 30

Date: _____

How I feel today (1-10):

The guilt I’m carrying today:

What I wish I could say to them:

Where I found light today (even a flicker):

One truth I need to hear right now:

Evening prayer or reflection:

COMMON MYTHS ABOUT SUICIDE - DEBUNKED

MYTH: It was selfish.

TRUTH: They were in unbearable pain and saw no other way out.

MYTH: You should have seen the signs.

TRUTH: Many people hide their pain. This is not your fault.

MYTH: Talking about it is dangerous.

TRUTH: Open conversation reduces stigma and saves lives.

MYTH: They didn't love you enough to stay.

TRUTH: Mental illness distorts thinking. Their love was real.

MYTH: You'll 'get over it' with time.

TRUTH: You learn to carry it differently. Grief has no timeline.

MYTH: They are in a 'better place' (if unhelpful).

TRUTH: You're allowed to be angry about platitudes.

COMPLICATED GRIEF vs NORMAL GRIEF

All grief after suicide is painful. But seek help if you notice:

- Intense longing that doesn't lessen after 6+ months
- Inability to accept the death
- Feeling life has no meaning or purpose
- Difficulty trusting others
- Emotional numbness or detachment
- Feeling that part of you died too
- Avoiding reminders of the loss entirely
- Suicidal thoughts of your own

These are signs of Prolonged Grief Disorder. Help is available.

A grief therapist specializing in suicide loss can help.

MY SUPPORT NETWORK

People I can call when the grief is heavy:

Name: _____ Phone: _____ Relation: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____ Relation: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____ Relation: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____ Relation: _____

My therapist/counselor: _____

My support group: _____

What helps when I'm spiraling:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

SURVIVOR SUPPORT GROUP LOG

Meeting 1 Date: _____ **Group:** _____

What resonated: _____

How I felt after: _____

Meeting 2 Date: _____ **Group:** _____

What resonated: _____

How I felt after: _____

Meeting 3 Date: _____ **Group:** _____

What resonated: _____

How I felt after: _____

Meeting 4 Date: _____ **Group:** _____

What resonated: _____

How I felt after: _____

Meeting 5 Date: _____ **Group:** _____

What resonated: _____

How I felt after: _____

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

ANNIVERSARY & BIRTHDAY COPING PLAN

Important dates to prepare for:

Their birthday: _____

Anniversary of their death: _____

Holidays: _____

Our special dates: _____

My plan for hard days:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

RESOURCES:

- 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988
- AFSP (American Foundation for Suicide Prevention): afsp.org
- Alliance of Hope for Suicide Loss Survivors: allianceofhope.org
- Survivors of Suicide Loss: soslsd.org
- Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741